SHOPFLOW CURRICULUM · PART E

Career & Interview Readiness

Reviewer Edition, v2 — Redesigned Final Phase

Panel verdict. The prior edition of Phase 10 got a motivated student to a competent first-pass resume and a passable interview, but under-prepared them for everything hiring now tests beyond raw coding ability: sourcing opportunities, surviving take-homes, reviewing real code (including AI-assisted review), presenting decisions to non-engineers, negotiating, and standing out against hundreds of similar portfolios. This edition folds every missing skill directly into the sequence — including moving the two small portfolio projects to **Week 1** so students have a three-project portfolio in hand before resume, brand, and networking work begins.

Annotated by an Engineering Manager, Staff Software Engineer, Technical Interviewer, and Senior Technical Recruiter panel · Reviewed for ATS, FAANG, and internship pipelines

Contents

1. What Changed From the Original Curriculum

Area	Original gap	What this edition does about it
Resume	No ATS guidance, no per-posting tailoring.	ATS-safe formatting pass + tailoring checklist per application (Week 3).
Portfolio	Single year-long project reads as one tutorial followed to completion.	Three-project portfolio, **built starting Week 1** instead of Week 3, so range is visible from the first resume draft onward.
GitHub	No commit hygiene, no reviewer-skim standard.	90-second reviewer skim checklist + commit-message standard (Week 1).
LinkedIn / networking	One-time profile pass; no outreach strategy.	Ongoing Networking & Recruiter Communication track (Week 4).
System design	No API design, no feature-design prompt.	REST/API conventions + "design a new feature" exercise added (Week 2).
Security	Self-audit only, no review-of-others'-code.	Folded into the Code Review track, plus a new AI-assisted review pass (Week 2).
Behavioral	No negotiation or "why this company" prep.	Negotiation and company-research prep (Weeks 4–5).
Technical interviews	One mock format only.	Five-round mock circuit: DSA, system design, pair/collab, **debugging**, behavioral (Week 5).
Mock interviews	Single pass, no rubric, no recording.	Scored rubric per round; rounds 1, 3, and 4 recorded for self-review.

Net structural change: six topics become **eight**, spread across **five weeks** instead of four. The extra week is not padding — it is the space needed to genuinely cover AI-assisted code review, ADR writing, debugging interviews, stakeholder communication, and scope/time management without compressing any topic below the point of usefulness. Every project is still hands-on and timeboxed; nothing here is a lecture.

2. Topic Coverage Map

Every skill area requested for this revision, and exactly where it now lives in the sequence.

Topic	Where covered	Status
Resume	Week 3	IMPROVED ATS pass + tailoring step added
Portfolio	Weeks 1 & 3	MOVED EARLIER 3-project build in Wk 1, polish/audit in Wk 3
GitHub	Week 1	IMPROVED skim checklist + commit standard added
LinkedIn	Week 3	IMPROVED brand-aligned refresh
Networking	Week 4	NEW TRACK
Personal branding	Week 3	NEW one-line positioning across all profiles
Technical writing	Week 3	NEW ADR-based deep-dive post
ADR presentation	Weeks 1 & 4	NEW write in Wk 1, present to "stakeholders" in Wk 4
Open source	Week 3	NEW one merged PR target
Code review	Week 2	IMPROVED peer PR + external OSS PR
AI-assisted code review	Week 2	NEW
Behavioral interviews	Weeks 4–5	IMPROVED negotiation + no-good-story cases added
Mock interviews	Week 5	IMPROVED 5-round rubric circuit
System design	Week 2	IMPROVED + API design
Debugging interviews	Weeks 2 & 5	NEW
Salary negotiation	Week 5	NEW
Internship-specific prep	Week 4	NEW
Junior engineer expectations	Week 4	NEW
Reading large codebases	Week 4	NEW
Pair programming	Weeks 2 & 4	NEW
Communication	Week 4	NEW
Stakeholder presentations	Week 4	NEW
Time management	Week 4	NEW
Scope management	Week 4	NEW

3. The Portfolio Strategy — Sequenced Early

One capstone read as "followed a tutorial for a year" even when it wasn't. The fix is unchanged in substance — ship ShopFlow plus two small, fast, contrasting projects — but the *timing* moves: both small projects are now built in **Week 1** instead of Week 3, so that every later exercise (resume bullets, LinkedIn, brand statement, networking pitch, mock interviews) can reference all three projects instead of retrofitting them in.

Project	Timebox	Built	Purpose
ShopFlow (existing)	Year-long (as-is)	Complete	Depth: full-stack ownership, auth, data modeling, deployment, scaling story, one authored ADR.
Tiny public API + docs	1 weekend	**Week 1** MOVED	API design taste and technical writing outside a monolith app.
CLI tool / automation script	1 weekend	**Week 1** MOVED	Scripting and tooling instincts, initiative unprompted by a course.
Merged open-source PR	Ongoing, target 1 by Week 3	Weeks 1–3	External validation — someone else's codebase and review process accepted your work.

Why move it: resume bullets, the LinkedIn featured section, the personal-brand statement, and the mock-interview "walk me through your portfolio" question are all stronger with three shipped projects behind them than with one. Building the small projects first also gives students a low-stakes rep at API design and CLI tooling before the higher-stakes system-design and code-review work in Week 2.

4. Phase 10 Redesigned — Structure at a Glance

Week	Focus	Key deliverables
1	Portfolio Expansion & GitHub Foundation	API project, CLI project, GitHub hygiene pass, first ADR written
2	System Design, API Craft & Code Review	Feature-design exercise, OWASP audit, peer + OSS code review, AI-assisted review, debugging warm-up
3	Resume, Brand, Writing & Open Source	ATS resume, portfolio polish, brand statement, blog post #1, one merged PR, LinkedIn refresh
4	Networking, Communication & Applied Skills	Outreach + recruiter templates, stakeholder presentation, take-home, pair session, codebase-reading exercise, scope/time drill
5	Mock Interview & Negotiation Sprint	5-round mock circuit, salary research + script, final readiness review

Envelope: 5 weeks (up from 4), reflecting the additional graded material. Each week still runs 3–5 hands-on items — no lecture-only days.

5. Week 1 — Portfolio Expansion & GitHub Foundation

Week 1

Build the range the portfolio is missing, then make the whole GitHub presence reviewable in 90 seconds

Portfolio — two small contrasting projects MOVED FROM WK 3

Recruiters expect range across a UI-heavy piece, a data/API piece, and a scripting piece — not just one long capstone.

- **Tiny public API + docs** (1 weekend): a small REST API with a real README, example requests, and a versioning note.
- **CLI tool or automation script** (1 weekend): solves one real personal problem — not a tutorial clone.

GitHub hygiene

A reviewer skims a profile for well under two minutes; the repo has to sell itself instantly.

- Pin ShopFlow + the two new projects; write a profile README with a one-line positioning statement (draft version — refined in Week 3).
- **90-second reviewer skim checklist:** clear repo name → README opens with what/why/stack → one setup command that works → screenshot or GIF → linked live demo.
- **Commit-message standard:** imperative mood, present tense, one logical change per commit (e.g. "*add rate limiting to /orders endpoint*", not "*fixes*").
- Prune or archive dead repos so the pinned six are the only story a reviewer sees.

ADR presentation — first draft NEW

Explaining a real decision, in writing, is what separates "wrote code" from "made engineering calls" — and it's reused as a blog post and an interview answer later.

- Write one Architecture Decision Record for ShopFlow's most consequential call (e.g. why Redis, why this schema, why this auth approach).
- Standard sections: Context → Decision → Alternatives considered → Consequences (including the tradeoff you accepted).
- Keep it to one page. This draft feeds directly into Week 3's technical-writing post and Week 4's stakeholder presentation.

End of Week 1 checklist

- ☐ API project live with README and working setup instructions
- ☐ CLI project committed with a clear problem statement in its README
- ☐ GitHub profile passes the 90-second skim test (ask a peer to time themselves)
- ☐ One ADR written for a ShopFlow decision

6. Week 2 — System Design, API Craft & Code Review

Week 2

Design under constraints, then practice giving and receiving review — from humans and from AI

System design + API craft

- Original scaling narrative retained: caching, load balancing, a scaling story for ShopFlow.
- **Added:** REST conventions and versioning applied to the Week 1 API project.
- **Added:** a "design a feature ShopFlow doesn't have yet" prompt (e.g. wishlists, reviews) — requirements-gathering first, tradeoffs stated out loud, no code required.

Security & code review

- OWASP self-audit on the student's own code (retained from the original).
- **Peer review:** review a partner's PR and leave three substantive, specific, kind comments.
- **Open-source review:** comment constructively on one external OSS PR in the student's stack.

AI-assisted code review NEW

AI review tools are now a standard part of a junior engineer's daily workflow — and interviewers increasingly ask how candidates use them responsibly.

- Run an AI code-review tool against the same PR a human peer reviewed; compare the two sets of feedback side by side.
- Identify at least one false positive (AI flagged something that isn't actually a problem) and one true gap (something a human caught that the AI missed, or vice versa).
- Write two sentences on when to trust AI review output versus when to escalate to a human — this becomes a ready behavioral-interview answer about working with AI tools responsibly.

Debugging interviews — warm-up NEW

Distinct from DSA: debugging interviews test process (reproduce → isolate → hypothesize → verify), not clever solutions.

- Given a deliberately broken snippet (not written by the student), narrate the debugging process out loud before touching the fix.
- Practice the loop: reproduce the failure → form one hypothesis at a time → verify with the smallest possible test → only then change code.
- This is revisited as a full mock round in Week 5.

7. Week 3 — Resume, Brand, Writing & Open Source

Week 3

Now that three projects exist, make every surface (resume, site, profiles, writing) tell the same story

Resume

- Impact-bullet rewrite across all three projects (retained from original): quantify honestly, outside review.
- **Added:** ATS-safe formatting pass — standard section headers, no tables/graphics in the parsed version, one page.
- **Added:** a tailoring checklist run once per real application — match 3–5 keywords from the posting without keyword-stuffing.

Portfolio site polish & personal branding BRAND IS NEW

- Lighthouse / accessibility audit on the portfolio site; fix mobile layout, load time, and any broken links.
- Write one positioning statement (one line) and align resume, GitHub, LinkedIn, and the portfolio site around it.

Technical writing & blog NEW

- Expand the Week 1 ADR into a full deep-dive post explaining the decision and its tradeoffs to an outside reader.
- Stand up a simple blog on the portfolio site and publish the post as entry #1.

Open source contributions NEW

- Find two repos in the student's stack labeled "good first issue."
- Submit one real pull request — small is fine; a merged PR is the target set in Week 1's portfolio plan.

LinkedIn

- Headline and About refresh using the new positioning statement (retained from original).
- Feature all three portfolio projects, not just ShopFlow; confirm the tech stack listed is accurate.

8. Week 4 — Networking, Communication & Applied Skills

Week 4
Practice the collaborative and communication skills that live outside solo coding

Networking NEW
- Message 5 alumni or engineers at target companies with a specific, non-generic ask.
- Attend one meetup or virtual event.

Recruiter communication NEW
- Draft and practice three templates: initial outreach, timeline-nudge follow-up, offer/negotiation reply.

Communication & stakeholder presentations NEW
- Deliver a 5-minute non-technical walkthrough of ShopFlow's Week 1 ADR to a peer playing a PM or exec role — no jargon, decision and impact only.

Time & scope management NEW
- Retrospective: where did ShopFlow's actual scope diverge from the original plan, and why?
- Timed drill: given a shrunk deadline, decide out loud what gets cut first and why.

Pair programming NEW
- 45 minutes with a peer adding a small feature; switch driver/navigator roles halfway.

Reading unfamiliar codebases NEW
- Clone a mid-size open-source repo; in 30 minutes, map its structure and explain one feature's data flow.

Take-home assignments NEW
- Complete one realistic 3–4 hour take-home under a real clock; submit with the README a reviewer expects.

Internship prep & junior expectations NEW
- Research target companies' OA tooling (HackerRank/Codility) and return-offer conversion rates.
- Review a first-90-days checklist: how to ask for help, how to scope a first ticket, how feedback is typically delivered.

9. Week 5 — Mock Interview Circuit & Negotiation Sprint

Week 5
Five rounds, one rubric each, two rounds recorded for self-review — then negotiate

Rd	Format	Setup	Rubric focus
1	DSA solo (recorded)	45 min, 1 medium LeetCode problem, think-aloud, on video call not chat.	Clarifies problem, verbalizes approach before coding, tests own solution.
2	System design	30 min, "design a feature ShopFlow doesn't have yet" (e.g. wishlists, reviews).	Asks requirements-gathering questions first, states tradeoffs, doesn't over-engineer.
3	Pair / collaborative (recorded)	45 min, adds a small feature to a partner's unfamiliar codebase together.	Asks before assuming, narrates intent before typing, reads existing code first.
4	Debugging NEW	30 min, a deliberately broken feature in an unfamiliar file the student hasn't seen.	Reproduces before changing anything, forms one hypothesis at a time, verifies each fix.
5	Behavioral + take-home debrief (recorded)	30 min behavioral from the STAR bank, then defends the Week 4 take-home's decisions live.	Answers are specific and 60–90s, no rambling, can defend tradeoffs under follow-up questions.

Escalation rule (unchanged): a student who can't watch their own recording of Round 1, 3, or 5 without wincing isn't done practicing that round. Repeat before moving on.

Salary negotiation NEW
- Research a real range for the target role and location using levels.fyi and Glassdoor.
- Write and practice one counter-offer script out loud, including how to respond to "what's your current salary."

10. Progress Tracker & Job-Ready Bar

Weekly tracks completed

- ☐ Week 1 — Portfolio Expansion & GitHub Foundation
- ☐ Week 2 — System Design, API Craft & Code Review
- ☐ Week 3 — Resume, Brand, Writing & Open Source
- ☐ Week 4 — Networking, Communication & Applied Skills
- ☐ Week 5 — Mock Interview Circuit & Negotiation Sprint

Deliverables checklist

- ☐ 3-project portfolio live (ShopFlow + API + CLI/script)
- ☐ One ADR written and one turned into a published blog post
- ☐ One merged open-source PR
- ☐ 5/5 mock interview rounds passed against rubric
- ☐ One completed timed take-home
- ☐ One stakeholder-style presentation delivered

Job-ready bar (updated): explain ShopFlow's architecture and its ADR out loud to both an engineer and a non-technical stakeholder, point to a live deployed URL with a second and third portfolio piece behind it, solve a medium LeetCode problem and a debugging scenario under time pressure, show one merged open-source PR, and clear all five mock-interview rounds. That combination — not any single week alone — is what gets you hired.

11. Study Resources

Resource	Use for	Link
levels.fyi & Glassdoor	Salary research	https://www.levels.fyi
Up For Grabs	Beginner-friendly open-source issues	https://up-for-grabs.net
RESTful API design guidance	API craft (Week 2)	https://restfulapi.net
GitHub Docs — About pull requests	Open source & code review (Weeks 2–3)	https://docs.github.com/en/pull-requests
NeetCode 150-style checklist	LeetCode pattern coverage (Week 5 prep)	Pattern-tag each problem attempted